INDIVIDUAL LEARNING REPORT

Version: 1.0

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Part 1: Learning Objectives

Professional Expertise

I want to gain more knowledge of how users can be authenticated. During the project, I will be responsible for the authentication of our application. I have no previous knowledge about this IT subject, so it will be very interesting and challenging for me. This learning objective can be measured by looking at the end result of the project, where the user will be able to log into the application.

Learning Ability

Unfortunately due to covid-19, we need to make this project from our homes. This can be quite challenging for me because there are a lot of distractions at home. I want to learn what my weak and strong points are. So that I can work on my weak points and thrive on my strong points. I am going to accomplish this by reflecting every 4 weeks, on my work drive and how long I can stay focused. This learning objective can be measured by the retrospectives after every sprint. This will start on 11 March.

Communication Skills

I want to accomplish that my team has a structured and clear way of communication. Especially since we are all working from home I think it is very important. I am going to accomplish this by taking up the role of the secretary in my team. This means that I am responsible for making the planning, including managing the deadlines of the project. I will be sending active reminders to team members when necessary. This learning objective can be measured by asking for feedback from my team members at the end of the project.

Part 2: Lessons learned part 1

Sprint number: 1
Date: 06-04-2021

Activities
During the sprint, I worked on securing our API by making use of bearer authentication. This can be used later to implement user authentication. To get this working I made use of Azure Active Directory to secure our API. Once this is done I secured our API endpoints, the last point that needs to get done is writing the necessary code into the client app. This will be done by the front-end team and not me. To help them I made a document where all the data is collected that is needed and the resources to make it work. That's how I worked on my professional expertise.

I worked on my learning ability by reflecting on myself during the retrospective. One point that stood out to me was that I find it hard to ask for help. For example, I needed to get acquainted with the API instead of asking Mathijs or Timber I tried to do it on my own. Unfortunately, this took too much time and I still had to ask for their help. In the future, I want to push myself to quickly ask for help if this is necessary. This way I can get more things done in a shorter time frame and that is what I want.

Unfortunately, we are all working from home and this makes communication difficult sometimes. I made sure to send reminders when a deadline was approaching. I also made an agenda for when we need to have finished certain individual assessments so that we can add those to our group assessment. I found it efficient that in one look, my team members have an overview of what needs to get done.

Learned lessons
I asked my team members for feedback, they liked that I keep an eye on the deadlines to make sure everyone finishes it on time. The role that I have in this team is the secretary, I like that my team members think that I am fulfilling my role well. Besides that, I have received the feedback that I bring a positive atmosphere to the team and have a proactive work attitude. Unfortunately, my proactive attitude can be overwhelming for other team members. That’s why in the next sprint I want to give everyone their space to talk. The last point that was mentioned is that I need to try to ask for help in time and involve myself in the work of others. This way I avoid realizing too late that I am doing double or wrong work. I learned from this sprint that my teams think that I am an involved and active member. However, there are still some points that I need to work on as mentioned above.

Sprint number: 2
Date: 11-05-2021

Activities
During this sprint, I worked on user authentication in the back-end. All of our data is stored in the MongoDB database. My task was to add users to the database by making use of a jwt token. Next to that, I worked on creating an API endpoint, where I made a function where the requests that are from the user are only seen by him. This is how I worked on my professional expertise.

I worked on my learning ability by reflecting on myself during the retrospective. One point that stood out to me is that I wasn't really motivated this sprint. This could have been because of the vacation that was in between and some personal situations. In the future, I want to share this with my team members so that they are aware of the situation.

I sadly have to announce that we are still working from home, we hope that in the future of the project we will be able to meet. I made sure during this sprint that everyone was heard in a team meeting, besides that I keep reminding everyone about the deadlines. I updated the agenda that I made last time. We still haven't missed a deadline and to this point, our product owner is satisfied with our progression and our communication towards him.

Learned lessons

I asked my team members for feedback, overall they found that I was an easy person to collaborate with. Next to that am I an active thinker when we are having a brainstorming session. In the last sprint, there was the point that I interrupted people while they were talking. During this sprint, I received the feedback, that they felt that I worked on this and got better at giving people the space to talk. The following point was that I sometimes feel that I haven't done a lot, while this is the case. The reason for this is because certain features of our application need a lot of research. While I am doing this and not writing any code I don't feel like I contributed to the team. I need to have more confidence in my work because if I don't have it nobody else will have it either.

Part 3: Midterm self-reflection

During a feedback meeting with my team members, I have received feedback on the following competencies below:

Professional expertise: I always finish my work on time, one thing that helps me with this is working with scrum. This is the first time that I am working with this structure in a professional setting. By clearly describing what I want to do in a sprint and giving a time estimating so that my team and I indicated the work that needs to be doing. I have received the feedback that my user stories are clearly written, the improvement part here is that in the next sprint I need to add a definition of done.

Research skills: One of my responsibilities during this project is setting up the authentication for our application, because I haven't got any knowledge about this subject I needed to investigate a lot. On the internet I looked for multiple tutorials and documentation, I also attended meetings with developers. I received feedback from these developers that they found that I had a creative mindset and a general understanding of the subject. I can find relevant information and distills the essence from this information.

Communication skills: My team members found that I always reminded them about the deadlines and important upcoming events. Next to that, I made a general agenda where all the deliverables are described and what needs to be done for this.

Collaboration skills: Our team is split in half, one part of the team works on the front-end and the other half on the back-end. I work on the back-end with Timber and Mathijs, one particular thing that they mentioned is that I need to ask for help faster. During the last sprint, it was the case, that I waited too long to ask for help. This resulted in that it took me twice the amount of time to finish a task. In this next sprint, I want to give myself a maximum of 2 hours to figure something out for myself. If I still haven't found the answer I will ask for help from one of my team members.

The positive feedback that I received was that I am a great motivator during the meetings to keep ideas and productivity high. I involve others in conversations, ask for their input, and am not afraid to make decisions. Besides that, they feel that I am a person who can always be contacted to discuss something (after project hours). I am really glad to hear that my team members feel that I have a proactive work attitude.

Learning ability: The feedback that I have received from my team members is that I don't need to be afraid to speak my mind and give feedback to other people. I can find myself in this because we all work online I am cautious of my words so that I don't unintentionally offend a member of my team. However, after hearing this feedback I think that I have been too cautious, in the next sprint I will speak up more if this is necessary.

Part 4: Learning Objectives for the second half of the project

I don’t want to alter my current learning objectives, I feel like I am doing a good job at working on my learning objectives however I am not fully satisfied with the result. I still want to develop myself further on these learning objectives.

Part 5: Learned lessons part 2

Sprint number: 3
Date: 09-06-2021

Activities
During this sprint I worked on the login authentication, I made a with Timber and Mathijs a complete login flow. Now the user can log into the application and the items that are from that user are displayed. For this, to work we made use of B2C authentication on Azure, our API. Now we once a user login into the application, there is an access token generated. In this token the e-mail of the user is present, this is matched to the e-mails that are in the database. If there are any matches then these items will be displayed to the user.

First, we made a test project, because we first needed to understand how to complete the login flow. Once we had the test project working we implemented this in our project for the client and this worked fine. This is how I worked on my professional expertise.

I worked on my learning ability by reflecting on myself during the retrospective. One point that really stuck to me is that I got demotivated when we were working on login authentication. This was caused by that I didn't have the correct rights to work in the environment (Azure) to get things done. In the future, I want to make sure that I have everything necessary before I start working on a project.

Learned lessons
I asked my team members for feedback, I received the following feedback. I live up to my role as the secretary and make sure that there is a solid agenda for every month. Next to that I am always motivated to solve a problem, I never give up. At last, when somebody else isn't very motivated or doesn't know what to do I won't hesitate to motivate or help them. This was the positive feedback now I will have a look at the negative feedback. Sometimes my team members don't know what I am working on, they would like this so they can help me when this is necessary. Another point was that I seemed afraid to take the lead when we were working on technical tasks, I agree with this and will be working on this in the future.

Part 6: Final self-reflection

During a feedback meeting with my team members, I have received feedback on the following competencies below:

Professional expertise: During this project, I mostly worked on the authentication part. I learned how to implement user login flow for an Android and iOS application using Azure. Besides that, I also learned how you can protect an API against third unwanted parties. To implement a user login flow I needed to learn how our frontend, backend, API, and database works. I really liked this challenged cause, it made me learn multiple parts of the application instead of one. The feedback that I have received from my team members is when I am working together on a technical task, that I can appear afraid to take the lead. In the following project, I want to appear more confident.

Research skills: As mentioned above, I worked on the authentication part of the project. When starting this project I didn't have any idea how authentication works. This resulted in that I had to a lot of research and try different ways of making the authentication work. When I presented possible solutions to our developer from Wortell he seemed pleased with them. During the project, it became easier for me to distill the essence from the information and through this find creative solutions. The feedback that I have received from my team members is that I often present relevant information and that I have an open mind to talk about different solutions.

Communication skills: During the project, I had the role of the secretary, this meant that I had to keep track of all the upcoming deadlines and make an agenda for every month. My team appreciated this very much, this way they didn't have to check every time if something needs to get done. What I have learned from this is that a general agenda is an asset to a team to create stability. Next to that, I learned to make compromises because I am not the only person in a team. I learned that when I want to get a point across I have to give good arguments to support them, this makes me seem more logical and trustworthy.

Collaboration skills: The collaboration in the team went generally well, there were a few occasions where we had a discussion and couldn’t get to a solution. As a team, we managed to face some difficult situations, but because of our patience and respect for each other we were able to come to an understanding. I mostly worked with Timber and Mathijs on the backend, the feedback that I received from them is that I am an easy person to work with. I don't back down from new challenges and am a very positive person. For every problem I never give up to find a solution.

Learning ability: The feedback that I have received from my team members I that I worked on the feedback that they gave me during the peer reviews. During the mid-term review, I got the feedback that I am an enthusiastic person but this can be overwhelming for some people. At the final peer review, I didn't get any comments on this improvement point. Next to that people feel that they can always come to me when they are bothered with something and that I am an open person to give feedback to. What I have learned so far is, how to work with a team completely online and still create a fun and productive environment to work in.